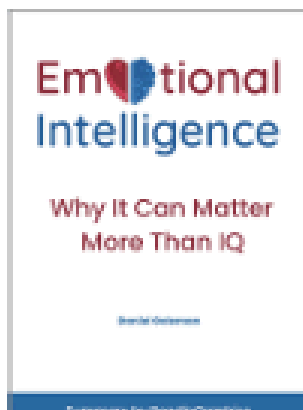




EMOTIONAL INTELLIGENCE

Why It Can Matter More Than IQ

DANIEL GOLEMAN



Introduction

Data suggests that emotional intelligence is a much better predictor of success than academic intelligence in various aspects of life. This was one of the first books to comprehensively review the research, insights and implications of emotional intelligence. The book was organized into 5 parts on the emotional brain, emotional intelligence, applications, societal influences and emotional literacy. In this summary, we've consolidated the insights into 4 sections to explain the biology and neurology behind emotions, the dangers of emotional illiteracy, and how to develop emotional intelligence for better outcomes.



1. Emotions and the Human Brain



Emotions are strong impulses that drive us to take action. They're nature's way to guide our actions, primarily to help us survive.

- Each emotion primes us for a different type of action. For example, anger increases our heart-rate and blood circulation to unlock energy so we can confront an enemy. Surprise causes the eyes to widen so we can take in more of our surroundings to figure out what's happening. Love helps us to relax, cooperate and feel contented.
- Our biological makeup comes from 50,000 generations of evolution. Yet our lifestyle has changed drastically in the last 5-10 generations alone. Our biological evolution hasn't caught up with our new realities, and problems arise when our emotions are out of sync with the situation.

KEY QUOTES

"Emotional intelligence [is] a meta-ability, determining how well or how poorly people are able to use their other mental capacities."

"All emotions are, in essence, impulses to act, the instant plans for handling life that evolution has instilled in us."



The Architecture of the Human Brain



The human brain is about 3x the size of primates'. It evolved from the bottom-up over millions of years.

- The brainstem (at the top of the spinal cord) is the most "primitive" part of the brain. It runs our body's key functions (e.g. breathing, digestion) automatically.
- The first mammals developed a new limbic system on top of the brainstem. This is responsible for our basic emotions, and gives us the ability to learn and adapt to new environments.
- About 100mil years ago, the neocortex (or frontal lobe) was formed on top of the limbic system. This is our rational mind or thought-center, which enables us to integrate and analyze data, manage our senses and emotions, and make conscious decisions. Humans (*Homo Sapiens*) have a much larger neocortex than other species, giving us superior intellect and a much wider range of responses.



So, we effectively have 2 minds: an emotional mind that's intuitive and impulsive, and a rational mind that's thoughtful and analytical.

- Since our thinking brain evolved from our emotional brain, our thoughts and feelings are linked. Most of the time, they feed off each other to provide deeper insights and help us to make better decisions. However, we can feel conflicted when our logic tells us 1 thing while our feelings tell us another.
- Moreover, our emotional brain is older and more dominant, especially during emergencies. When the amygdala is aroused by intense feelings, it's more likely to override your rational mind. This is your body's way of protecting you in times of peril, e.g. you may intuitively jump away from a table before you realize that someone spilt a bowl of hot soup.

KEY QUOTES

"In a very real sense we have two minds, one that thinks and one that feels....These two fundamentally different ways of knowing interact to construct our mental life."



What Happens During Emotional Hijacking

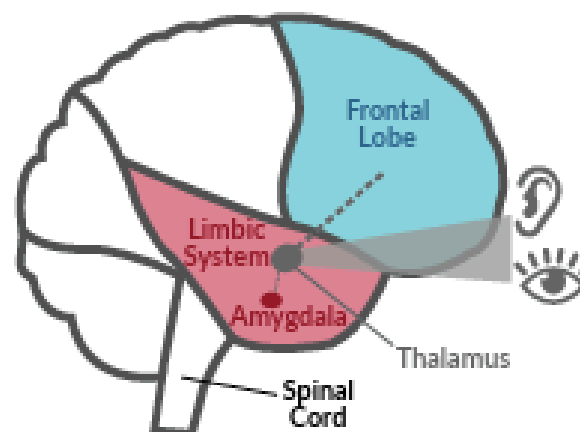


Emotional hijacking happens when we act on impulse before the logical brain has had the chance to assess the situation and choose a response. For example, we may laugh uncontrollably at a funny incident, or lash out defensively at a snide remark.



The amygdala is the emotional-center of our brain, and we have 2 amygdalas on either side of the brainstem.

- The amygdala is responsible for our feelings and emotional memory. Without it, you'll lose the ability to feel and understand others' feelings. You'll also lose all sense of personal values and the desire to compete/collaborate with others.
- The amygdala is constantly scanning for potential threats. Once it perceives a threat, it acts like a tripwire to instantly send out a crisis message to the rest of your brain, hijacking most of the brain functions including your rational mind.
- Sensory information from our eyes/ears go to the brain's thalamus. From there, 1 synapse goes to the neocortex which processes the signals before routing them to other parts of the brain (including the amygdala). Another synapse goes directly from the thalamus to the amygdala. The amygdala can react faster than the neocortex since (i) its pathway to the thalamus is shorter and smaller, and (ii) the neocortex takes a moment to process the data before responding.



- Our brain stores “normal” facts separately from emotionally-charged ones. Emotional memories are stored in the amygdala as raw impressions. The stronger the feelings (e.g. extreme thrill or fear), the deeper the imprint on the amygdala. When the amygdala encounters something associated with an old memory,

KEY QUOTES

“The amygdala acts as a storehouse of emotional memory, and thus of significance itself; life without the amygdala is a life stripped of personal meanings.”

“Our emotions have a mind of their own, one which can hold views quite independently of our rational mind.”

it will trigger a similar response. That's why we may instantly like or dislike something without knowing why.

- Unlike the neocortex, our amygdala is almost fully-formed at birth. This allows us to accumulate emotional memories even before we have the language/logic to articulate those experiences. These memories influence us throughout our lives in the form of raw, unconscious impulses. Problems arise when:
 - (i) The amygdala's memory is *out of date*, e.g. a former army nurse is terrified by the smell of her toddler's diaper because it reminds her of the stink of the battlefield.
 - (ii) It brings *errors and false alarms*. The thalamus' signal to the amygdala is meant as a rough warning, and contains only a fraction of the data sent to the neocortex. So, the amygdala doesn't have the full picture and reacts based on a few pieces of the puzzle.



Usually when an emotion is triggered, the prefrontal lobes will assess the situation and decide on the best course of action, e.g. whether to attack, flee, soothe, persuade, etc.

- The neocortex manages our emotions by (i) dampening the limbic center's activation signals while it processes the inputs, and (ii) providing an off-switch to moderate emotional surges. For example, you feel a wave of panic when you hear a series of gun-shots, then calm down when you realize they're just fire-crackers.
- Typically, your rational thoughts and emotions work together. You need emotions for effective thought, e.g. to choose a life partner or to weigh your priorities. A patient who lost the link between his 2 brains during a surgery could still think logically but lost all awareness of his feelings and preferences.
- Yet, strong feelings can disrupt your cognitive ability, making it hard to think clearly. Emotional trauma can also impair learning and increase the risks of depression, alcoholism, drugs, crime etc.

KEY QUOTES

"In the dance of feeling and thought the emotional faculty guides our moment-to-moment decisions, working hand-in-hand with the rational mind, enabling—or disabling—thought itself."

"IQ and emotional intelligence are not opposing competencies, but rather separate ones."

"Academic intelligence has little to do with emotional life...people with high IQs can be stunningly poor pilots of their private lives."

"Intelligence can come to nothing when the emotions hold away."



2. Emotional Intelligence



Emotional intelligence refers to your ability to exert self-control, regulate your moods, empathize with others, and motivate yourself to persist in face of setbacks.



Research suggests that a person's intelligence quotient (or "IQ") accounts for only 20% of our success in life. The remaining 80% comes from non-IQ factors, such as luck, social class and emotional intelligence.

- No matter how smart you are, you won't do well if you can't manage your emotional impulses. Children and adults with strong emotional skills were found to be more effective, contented, focused and productive, while being less likely to be sabotaged by internal turmoil.
- Moreover, IQ is fixed while emotional intelligence can be learned.



Goleman did a detailed review of the theories and insights from numerous researchers and psychologists, and presented 5 components of emotional intelligence (EI): self-awareness, self-regulation, self-motivation, empathy and relationship management. In his later books, he organized these into 4 categories: self-awareness, social-awareness, self-management and relationship-management. We'll elaborate on the 5 EI components in the sections below.



Self-Awareness: Know your Emotions



This is about being aware of your emotions as they arise, instead of being swept away by them. Instead of hitting someone with uncontrolled rage, you can observe that "I'm furious with him."

- This awareness shifts your mental activities to the neocortex, so your unconscious gut-feelings become conscious. You can evaluate your experience, and even notice your feelings about your feelings. This helps you to choose your responses and make sound decisions. For example, if you know why you're feeling irritable,

KEY QUOTES

"Intellect cannot work at its best without emotional intelligence."

"An inability to notice our true feelings leaves us at their mercy."

you can do something fix it, or simply shrug it off and move on.

- The stronger your emotional awareness, the more you'll be aware of what used to be unconscious, e.g. your deepest fears or desires. People who're self-aware generally have more clarity and control over their emotions. They enjoy better psychological health compared to people who get engulfed by their feelings, or passively accept their moods without trying to manage them.



Self-Regulation: Manage your Responses



We usually can't control our emotions when they first surface. However, once we're aware of them, we can manage our response to (i) determine how long those feelings last, and (ii) react in a way that's appropriate for the situation.

- We need both "good" and "bad" feelings. People who experience intense sadness and pain can still be mentally and emotionally healthy if they also feel extreme joy and happiness.
- Managing your emotions involves the ability to soothe yourself so you won't be incapacitated by feelings of distress, and can bounce back more quickly from setbacks. Anger, anxiety and sadness are 3 common feelings that people struggle with.



We get angry when we feel attacked physically or symbolically, e.g. when someone threatens or insults us. Anger brings a rush of energy to prime us for action, making it easier for the next strong feeling to trigger an emotional hijack. After a frustrating day, you're more likely to blow up at someone.

- Don't dwell on the reasons for your anger. One self-righteous thought will lead to another to fuel your rage. Giving vent to your anger also increases your arousal to make you more angry.

KEY QUOTES

"Emotions that simmer beneath the threshold of awareness can have a powerful impact on how we perceive and react, even though we have no idea they are at work."

"Downs as well as ups spice life, but need to be in balance."

*"Anyone can become angry—that is easy. But to be angry with the right person, to the right degree, at the right time, for the right purpose, and in the right way—this is not easy."
—Aristotle*

"Anger builds on anger...rage, unhampered by reason, easily erupts in violence."

- The best way to quench your anger is to pause asap and consider the opposite perspective. For example, if a driver cuts in right in front of you, you may rage at how the selfish bastard almost killed you with his careless driving. Diffuse your anger by reframing your assumptions, e.g. consider that he may not have seen you, or is having an emergency.
- Once your anger has escalated beyond a certain point, no amount of reasoning will help. In such cases, try to cool down first: go for a long walk, try some relaxation techniques, or exercise to release steam. The key is to distract yourself from the source of the anger.



When we're anxious, we tend to replay the problem in our minds to try and find a solution. However, we often get stuck in an unproductive worry-loop. Anxiety may come in the form of worrisome thoughts and or physiological symptoms (e.g. sweating, heart pounding).

- Chronic worrying tends to involve a catastrophic image which leads to all sorts of imaginary causes and outcomes. Chronic worriers may obsess over unlikely problems, then convince themselves that they had prevented the disaster from happening in the first place.
- To overcome anxiety: (i) recognize the cues for anxiety before you spiral downward, (ii) use relaxation techniques to ease your tension, and (iii) challenge the worrisome thought. Ask yourself: what's the probability of it occurring and what can you do to address it? If there's nothing you can do, then there's no point worrying. In extreme cases, you may need medication/therapy to disrupt the cycle of anxiety.



We feel sad when we've lost something or someone important. Melancholy helps us to shut down temporarily, conserve our energy, mourn the loss and regroup. However, you can fall into despair if you dwell on bad feelings without a viable course of action (e.g. thinking how tired/useless you are). You end up making mistakes, getting fired, etc. to worsen your confidence and negative feelings.

- To overcome depression:
 - (i) Challenge and reframe the depressing thoughts.

KEY QUOTES

*"Brooding fuels anger's flames.
But seeing things differently
douses those flames."*

"Empathy is a balm for anger."

"Bereavement is useful; full-blown depression is not."

"A passive immersion in the sadness simply makes it worse."

- (ii) Distract yourself with pleasant activities (e.g. exercise, watch a funny movie, read an uplifting book).
- (iii) Engineer a small win, e.g. dress up or finish some chores.
- (iv) Help others in need or compare with those who're worse-off.
- (v) Turn to a transcendent power e.g. praying to God.



Self-Motivation: Channel your Emotions Productively



This is about managing your impulses so they support your goals, including the ability to delay gratification, stay motivated, and channel your feelings productively.



The ability to delay gratification is an important emotional skill. In a study, 4 y.o. kids were given a choice: they could eat a marshmallow right away, or have 2 marshmallows if they waited for about 15min. The kids who held out for 2 marshmallows grew up to be more confident, reliable, and socially competent adolescents. They handled challenges better and had higher SAT scores (compared to the kids who couldn't resist grabbing the marshmallows).



When we face setbacks, people who get distressed cannot focus, learn or solve problems effectively. Those who stay motivated and persistent end up being more successful in all areas of life.

- Our moods affect our mental state. Bad moods tend to call up negative memories to make us more cautious and constrictive. Good moods, on the other hand, tend to enhance our creativity and problem-solving capacity. People who're consumed by worries also have little/no mental capacity left for their tasks.
- When faced with challenges, our self-efficacy—the belief that we can prevail—predicts how far we persist and how well we bounce back from failures. Being hopeful about the future also helps us to take constructive steps forward, instead of simply giving up.

KEY QUOTES

"Disputing the depressing thoughts vanquishes the gathering mood of gloom."

"Marshaling emotions in the service of a goal is essential for paying attention, for self-motivation and mastery, and for creativity."

"Emotions out of control impede the intellect."

"From the perspective of emotional intelligence, having hope means that one will not give in to overwhelming anxiety, a defeatist attitude, or depression in the face of difficult challenges or setbacks."

KEY QUOTES

- Famous psychologist Martin Seligman found that optimists tend to perform much better than pessimists because:

- (i) Optimists attribute failure to something specific within their control, e.g. "I failed because I used the wrong approach." So, they'll be motivated to find new solutions.
- (ii) Pessimists blame their failure on a broad reason beyond their control, e.g. "I'm just too stupid to get this right."



Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi used the term "flow" to describe people who're fully-absorbed in a state of enjoyable peak performance.

- People who're in flow learn faster, perform better, and feel joy and fulfillment from the task. This is emotional intelligence at its peak, since you're stretching yourself and harnessing your inner strengths without any anxiety.
- To get in flow, find a task you're skilled at, focus your attention on it and perform just at the edge of your current abilities, so you're neither bored nor anxious.



Empathy: Recognize others' emotions



People who are empathic are more attuned to others' needs and wants, making them more effective in a range of social interactions. However, to notice and influence others' emotions, you must first be able to know and manage your own emotions.

- Humans have a natural tendency to mirror or mimic others' expressions or nonverbal cues. We can sense and even "catch" others' moods. People who're more forceful in expressing their feelings tend to transmit their feelings to others. The more physically-attuned 2 parties are, the more synchronized their moods will become. By sending the right signals, great leaders and performers can move a huge audience.



Thomas Hatch and Howard Gardner identified 4 components of interpersonal intelligence:

"Flow occurs in that delicate zone between boredom and anxiety."

"Attunement to others demands a modicum of calm in oneself."

"We are all part of each other's tool kit for emotional change, for better or for worse."

- Organizing groups: to initiative and coordinate people's efforts;
- Negotiating solutions: to prevent, mediate or resolve conflicts;
- Personal connection: to get along with others by empathizing and connecting with them; and
- Social analysis: to identify and understand others' feelings, motives, and concerns.

People who lack these skills are socially-inept and awkward in social settings. They tend to get alienated or rejected because they have a poor sense of personal space, misinterpret others' body language, or fail to project the right cues.



Relationship Management: Manage others' emotions

Managing relationships is largely about managing emotions in others, which is partially addressed above. In the next section, we'll examine how all 5 components of emotional intelligence come together to affect outcomes in various aspects of life.



3. Applying Emotional Intelligence



Emotional Intelligence in Marriage



Divorce rates have been rising, as social pressure for couples to stay married declined over the generations. Emotional intelligence is now more crucial than ever to hold a marriage together.



A starting point is to recognize gender differences in handling relationships. From young, girls are socialized to be less outwardly-aggressive than boys. Adults are more likely to talk to girls about emotions and tend to their hurts, while boys are expected to be independent and "rough it out". The 2 genders end up with different emotional skills. Men tend to value independence while women value

KEY QUOTES

"Being able to manage emotions in someone else is the core of the art of handling relationships."

"The art of relationships is, in large part, skill in managing emotions in others."

"Boys take pride in a lone, tough-minded independence and autonomy, while girls see themselves as part of a web of connectedness."

connection. In a marriage, women usually prefer to talk through relationship issues. They get upset when the husbands avoid such discussions or fail to notice their feelings.

 John Gottman has studied hundreds of couples in a lab-setting, and can predict (with a 94% accuracy) if a couple will divorce within 3 years. Key warning signals in a relationship include:

- Harsh criticisms that target the person ("You're a selfish jerk"), instead of an action ("You didn't fix the rack as promised");
- Criticisms delivered regularly with contempt (including words/tone that convey disgust or insult, like "bitch" or "wimp"); and
- Stonewalling, where one party withdraws into stony silence.

These behaviors cause hurt and trigger defensive responses in the other party (counterattack or withdrawal) to further injure the relationship.

 There are 2 parallel conversions in any communication: what's said vs what's unsaid. You may say, "Would you like to check why the kids are screaming?" when you're thinking, "He just can't be bothered to help out." Your spouse detects and responds to the underlying toxic thoughts/feelings, triggering an emotional hijack.

- The more emotional hijacking occurs, the harder it is for the couple to recover. Gottman calls this "flooding". When a partner is continually flooded, he/she feels overwhelmed and thinks the worst of the other party. By this stage, even a harmless comment or gesture can spark a flooding, preventing the couple from working things out cordially.
- Men are more prone to flooding, get triggered at lower levels, and take longer to recover. They're also more likely to stonewall, which can cause huge emotional distress to their wives. She retaliates by criticizing him (which only triggers him further), and the situation escalates out of control.

KEY QUOTES

"When grievances simmer, they build and build in intensity until there's an explosion; when they are aired and worked out, it takes the pressure off."

 The solution is for couples to develop shared emotional intelligence, so you can break the vicious cycle and work things out before it's too late. Here are several key competencies to master:

- Recognize gender differences and agree on how to disagree:
 - (i) *Men*: realize that your wife is bringing up a grievance not to attack you, but to improve the relationship. Even if you disagree with her views, you can listen and empathize with her feelings. Often she'll calm down once she feels heard.
 - (ii) *Women*: be mindful not to use personal criticisms or show contempt. Reassure your spouse that you love him.
- Learn to calm yourself and your partner. Monitor your pulse rates during an upsetting discussion, and take a 20-min break once your pulse exceeds the normal rate by 10 beats/min (which signals the onset of flooding). Or, agree prior that either party can call for a time-out if you notice signs of flooding.
- Detoxify your self-talk. Catch your negative thoughts/feelings of victimization or self-righteousness (e.g. "I don't deserve this"). Pause to look for evidence to the contrary.
- Use Haim Ginott's XYZ formula to express a complaint constructively: "When you did X, it made me feel Y, and I'd rather you did Z instead."
- Listen and empathize. Learn to listen past the anger, e.g. if your wife shouts "Stop interrupting me!", focus on the message (and let her finish) instead of her tone. Calm down enough to listen for the feelings behind the words—if you can empathize with or mirror your partner's feelings, it'll quickly soothe the negative feelings. To shift to the positive, express your love for them, respect their viewpoint (even if you don't agree with it), and express something you appreciate about them.

 Such responses won't develop overnight. You must practice enough until they become your default response during an emotional crisis.

KEY QUOTES

"Men and women, in general, need different emotional finetuning."

"Listening is a skill that keeps couples together."



Emotional Intelligence at the Workplace



Job satisfaction can be boosted by emotional competences, e.g. being attuned to own/others' feelings, effective conflict management, and the ability to regularly work in flow. On the other hand, low morale and cowed workers often lead to lower productivity, more errors and accidents.



Managers can apply emotional intelligence in 3 key ways:

- Giving feedback effectively. We need feedback to know what's expected of us, where we stand, and where to improve.
 - (i) Avoid harsh personal criticisms or general complaints like "you always screw up". These are counter-productive since the receiving party will simply get defensive and ignore the message.
 - (ii) Instead, focus specifically on what was done well, what was done poorly, and how it can be changed. Ideally, do this face to face.
- Harnessing diversity. Workplace diversity can enhance creativity and entrepreneurial spirit, and provide a real competitive advantage in a global marketplace.
 - (i) It's a human instinct to be loyal to our groups and to be hostile to outsiders. Our personal prejudices are formed since childhood and are hard to change. We may not even be aware of our biases and stereotypes.
 - (ii) You can't remove personal biases, but you can stop them from being expressed. Make discrimination and harassment explicitly unacceptable in your company, and never turn a blind eye to such acts. Train your people on the benefits of diversity, and how to effectively speak up against prejudices (using a similar approach as effective feedback).
- Research suggests that one of the best ways to tap on intellectual capital is to improve how people work together.
 - (i) The success of a group depends less on individuals' IQ than the group IQ, i.e. how far they can create internal harmony to tap on team members' talents.

KEY QUOTES

"Leadership is not domination, but the art of persuading people to work toward a common goal."

"How criticisms are given and received goes a long way in determining how satisfied people are with their work, with those they work with, and with those to whom they are responsible."

"The psychological price of loyalty to one's own group can be antipathy toward another."

"It is more practical to try to suppress the expression of bias rather than trying to eliminate the attitude itself."

- (ii) Star performers don't shine due to their superior intellect, but how they motivate themselves, build trust/rapport to tap into people's ideas/info, and coordinate their teams' efforts.



Emotional Intelligence in Health and Medicine



The medical definition of a disease is very different from a patient's experience of the disease. There's now strong evidence that patients' emotional states can affect their disease progression and recovery.



In the book, Goleman provides an extensive review of research findings on the link between emotions and health. In a nutshell, our emotions affect our nervous system and a range of hormones, which in turn affect our immune system.

- Specifically, chronic anger, anxiety, and depression can increase people's susceptibility to diseases, impede recovery and increase the risk of death.
 - (i) People subject to prolonged anxiety and distress tend to suffer from poorer immunity and the onset of diseases (from heart disease to diabetes, asthma, and gastrointestinal disorders). Existing patients' symptoms are also worsened by stress and emotional distress.
 - (ii) Of all the emotions, anger is the most closely linked with risks of death from heart disease. Anger may trigger other emotions, flooding the body with stress hormones that increase the risks of cardiac arrest.
 - (iii) Depression worsens a range of health conditions, partially because the depressed patients are less compliant with their medical regimes. The sense of social isolation can also double the chance of illnesses or death.
- By contrast, positive feelings and social support seem to help with health and recovery.
 - (i) Optimistic patients are less likely than pessimistic patients to die after a heart attack. They also recover faster from a bypass surgery and paralyzing spinal injuries.

KEY QUOTES

"Historically, medicine in modern society has defined its mission in terms of curing disease—the medical disorder—while overlooking illness—the patient's experience of disease."

"Having people to turn to and talk with, people who could offer solace, help, and suggestions, protected them from the deadly impact of life's rigors and trauma."

- (ii) The number and quality of your *relationships* also seem to buffer the effects of stress. Bone marrow transplant patients and heart-attack survivors recovered faster and survived longer if they had close ties and emotional support.



Medical care professionals should address patients' psychological needs along with their medical needs.

- Teach patients to use relaxation techniques and to soothe themselves (including chronic anger, anxiety, depression and pessimism). Heart-attack patients who received anger-control training had 44% lower heart attack rates. Medical patients who receive psychotherapy in addition to surgery/medicine also fared better than those with a medical treatment alone.
- Encourage them to get social support. Patients with advanced breast cancer survived 2x as long when they attended weekly meetings with other patients (compared to those who coped on their own).
- Address patients' unanswered questions (which may spark fears and uncertainty) by proactively offering information or giving patients options for self-research.
- Emotional intelligence can even be incorporated into health education and disease prevention programs for (i) children (to build the right emotional foundations), (ii) people reaching retirement age (to help them cope with the aging process), and (iii) at-risk people (to help them cope with daily stress).



4. Windows of Opportunity for Change



The Role of Family



Children learn their first lessons on emotions through family life.

- From their time in the cot, babies start to develop a basic level of trust/distrust in human interactions, e.g. whether

KEY QUOTES

"Family life is our first school for emotional learning; in this intimate cauldron we learn how to feel about ourselves and how others will react to our feelings; how to think about these feelings and what choices we have in reacting; how to read and express hopes and fears."

their needs will be noticed and tended to when they cry. By the age of 3-4, toddlers' brains reach two-thirds of the adult size—distress during this period can impair the brain's learning centers with long-term implications.

- As children grow up, their daily interactions with adults also reinforce their emotional outlook and skills. Those who receive consistent encouragement tend to be more curious, confident and enjoy learning. Children who suffer from neglect end up even worse off than those who're abused.



Parents' emotional intelligence impact their children's emotional skills, since the children learn from what their parents say and do.

- Children who're violently punished since young (instead of being consoled) fail to learn what "care and concern" means. When other children get upset, they respond with aggression because that's the only approach they know. The severe lack of emotional skills often leads to learning difficulties, rejection by peers, and higher risks of depression or crime by adulthood.
- The 3 worst parenting styles are: (i) ignoring children's emotional upsets, (ii) accepting feelings passively (without managing them), or (iii) responding to feelings with contempt (e.g. dismissing children's feelings or disallowing them to express their feelings).
- The best results come from parents who use children's upsets as opportunities to coach them to identify, and soothe/manage their feelings. These children tend to be physiologically healthier and are well-liked by their peers and teachers.



Conquering your Temperaments



We're each born with temperaments, or basic dispositions based on our genetic makeup. Psychologist Jerome Kagan found at least 4 temperament types—timid, bold, upbeat, and melancholy—due to differences in the brain's emotional circuits. These affect (a) how easily a feeling is triggered, (b) how long it lasts, and (c) how intense it becomes.

KEY QUOTES

"Emotionally adept parents can do much to help their children with each of the basics of emotional intelligence: learning how to recognize, manage, and harness their feelings; empathizing; and handling the feelings that arise in their relationships."

- Timid people have neural circuits that're more easily triggered, e.g. their hearts start to beat faster even at low levels of stress. They avoid new/unfamiliar situations and are more prone to stress-related problems including heart palpitations and panic attacks. By contrast, bold people have higher natural thresholds for stress and uncertainty.
- Upbeat people have more activity in their left frontal lobes (associated with positive moods). They can stay unfazed and cheerful no matter the situation. On the other hand, melancholy people have a more active right frontal lobe. They're more prone to negative moods and emotional disorders.



Such genetic differences stay with us for life, but our innate predispositions can be magnified or dampened by our childhood experiences.

- For example, infants with an easily-excitabile amygdala can relearn their responses by kindergarten if their parents encourage them to overcome their fears instead of coddling or protecting them. Each time they calm themselves when they're afraid, their prefrontal circuits get to practice moderating the knee-jerk reactions of the amygdala.
- Many systems in our body have a critical formative period, during which the changes have a disproportionate impact on our subsequent development.
 - (i) If a child's eye is taped close for just a few weeks during the formative window, fewer synapses will be developed in that part of the brain, and the child will suffer from impaired vision in that eye even after the tape is removed.
 - (ii) At 10-18 months, the orbitofrontal area of the prefrontal cortex goes through a critical period of growth. During this period, if infants are picked up and held each time they cried, it'll reinforce the links between the neocortex and limbic brain. The neocortex becomes more effective in switching off distressful emotions, so the infants can soothe themselves.
- Our brains continue to change throughout our lives. Patients with obsessive-compulsive disorders (OCD) could

"The emotional lessons of childhood can have a profound impact on temperament, either amplifying or muting an innate predisposition."

change their brain circuits if they repeatedly exposed themselves to the item of obsession, forced themselves not to act upon it and questioned their fears.



The Costs of Emotional Illiteracy



The habits formed in childhood are critical because they define the brain's synaptic wiring. The more these are reinforced over time, the harder they are to change.



Yet, in many countries, there's a disturbing rise of juvenile drug use, violent crimes, unwanted pregnancies, mental illness and suicides. This is partially due to the lack of parental guidance as children grow up in single-parent or dual-income families. Symptoms of emotional illiteracy include: withdrawals and social issues, anxiety and depression, attention deficit, delinquent or aggressive behaviors.

- Bullies wrongly assume that they're being threatened or slighted. They jump into an antagonistic response without considering alternatives, thus building/reinforcing unhelpful mental circuits and beliefs like "only cowards back down during a fight."
- Depression in children/teens usually stem from a lack of relationship skills and the tendency to interpret setbacks in a pessimistic way. Each time they do badly in school or get rejected by peers, they attribute it to a fundamental flaw in themselves, reinforcing the sense of helplessness and despair.
- Children with eating disorders (bulimia, anorexia, or binge eating) or alcohol/drug abuse also use food, alcohol or drugs as a form of "self-medication" to escape their negative feelings.



Such problems can be minimized (or even prevented) by teaching children to adopt an optimistic view of challenges, identify and soothe their distress, and connect to a support network. Emotional-management training has been found to benefit all the issues above, and even to buffer the harmful effects of poverty and abuse. Without proper intervention, the emotional issues can take root and get

KEY QUOTES

"Temperament is not destiny."

amplified by adulthood. A good emotional literacy program should cover the range of competencies outlined above, including self-awareness, impulse control, evaluating options/consequences, and interpersonal skills.



Trauma and Emotional Relearning



Most emotional trauma can be healed. Post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD) is actually a form of limbic disorder. The traumatic experience is so vividly imprinted in the emotional circuits that the amygdala sounds the alarm at every cue that reminds it of the trauma. Someone who was mugged in a lift may be afraid of elevators and enclosed spaces, or panic whenever they see someone wearing a cap.



The best way to recover is to get patients to relearn their encounter and retrain the neocortex to manage the amygdala. There're 3 stages in trauma recovery:

- Regaining a sense of safety or control, by using medication or relaxation techniques to provide a window of calmness.
- Acknowledging the trauma and the loss it brought.
 - (i) By recounting the details of the trauma and putting your feelings into words, you extract the subconscious elements from amygdala to be processed by the neocortex, so you can understand and moderate those feelings. This must be done in a safe environment (e.g. with the help of a therapist), so the brain can recreate the scene without the same terror. With each retelling, the trauma loses its grip until the victim can fully mourn his/her losses and move on.
 - (ii) You can also get the trauma victims to express themselves using art as an emotional outlet and a window to recovery.
 - (iii) Children tend to use games as an outlet. After a tragic shootout in an elementary school, the kids started to reenact the shooting scene with toy guys, except in their games they may get to "win" by killing the gunman. This helped them to regain a sense of control and come to terms with the trauma.

KEY QUOTES

"Emotional lessons—even the most deeply implanted habits of the heart learned in childhood—can be reshaped. Emotional learning is lifelong."

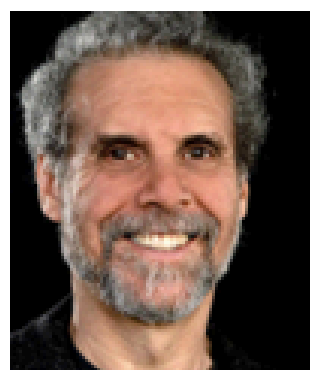
- Re-establishing a normal life. PTSD patients may continue to experience symptoms throughout their lives, but the traumatic memories no longer explode uncontrollably and they can revisit the memory without falling apart.



Other Details in the Book to Look out For

This book is packed with academic research, studies and examples about the human brain, psychology, and behavioral sciences. Goleman also includes appendices on emotions, the emotional mind, fear neural circuits, and the list of active ingredients for prevention programs. For more details please visit www.danielgoleman.info.

About the Author



Daniel Goleman (born 1946) is a psychologist, author, and science journalist. He was a visiting lecturer to Harvard, and wrote for The New York Times for 12 years, reporting on the brain and behavioral sciences. Besides authoring and coauthoring several books, he also cofounded the Collaborative for Academic, Social, and Emotional Learning, co-directed the Consortium for Research on Emotional Intelligence in Organizations and sat on the board of the Mind & Life Institute.

KEY QUOTES